Brief it like a *new hire.*

You already use AI. This is the other 90%, from how I run three jobs. Works on the free plan of Claude, ChatGPT and Gemini.

01 The four-part brief

Role
"You're my ops-savvy chief of staff."

Context
"Here's the situation, and what's been tried already." The part everyone skips.

Task
"Draft the plan. Flag the risks I'm not seeing."

Format
"One page, bullet points, plain English."

VAGUE

```
Prep me for a meeting with a new client tomorrow.
```

BRIEFED

```
You're my chief of staff. Tomorrow I meet the owner of a 12-branch retail chain for the first time. He's sceptical of AI and he's been burned by a software vendor before. I want to leave with a second meeting booked, not a sale. Give me five questions to ask him, three things he's probably worried about, and the one thing I shouldn't say. Bullet points, plain English.
```

02 My five everyday prompts · copy, fill the [brackets], send

Prep me for a meeting
Before any first call.

```
You're my chief of staff. Tomorrow I meet [who] about [what]. What I know so far: [context]. I want to leave with [outcome]. Give me five questions to ask, three things they're probably worried about, and the one thing I shouldn't say. Bullet points, plain English.
```

The follow-up
After a slow reply.

```
Draft a short follow-up to [name]. We last spoke on [date] about [topic] and they haven't replied. Warm, under 80 words, one clear ask: [ask]. No guilt-tripping.
```

Explain the numbers
For a client who doesn't read statements.

```
You're a patient finance manager. Explain [the attached summary] to a business owner who doesn't read financial statements. Use one everyday comparison, keep it under 150 words, and end with the one decision they need to make.
```

The long document
The one you've been avoiding.

```
Summarise [the attached document] for a [your role]. Give me the 5 points that matter most, each with the page or section it came from, so I can check them myself.
```

Say it in my voice
Emails that sound like you.

```
Rewrite this in my voice: direct, warm, no jargon. Here are 2 emails I wrote that sound like me: [paste]. Keep my meaning. Tell me if you changed any fact.
```

03 Never goes in a prompt

Nothing goes in that I wouldn't email to a stranger.

- Client and company names. Write [Client A] instead.
- TIN, SSS, PhilHealth and other ID numbers.
- Bank, card and account numbers.
- Salaries and payroll lines tied to a person.
- Passwords and logins. Ever.

Check your firm's AI policy. If there isn't one, that's your first Project. I'm not your lawyer: the National Privacy Commission says the Data Privacy Act applies when personal data is processed in developing or deploying AI systems (NPC Advisory No. 2024-04, 19 Dec 2024, on privacy.gov.ph).

04 The door rule

Can you undo it?

Yes. Let the AI act.
Matching a ledger, sorting files, drafting a reply, filling a template.

No. A person approves.
Paying, filing, sending to a client, anything with your signature on it.

AI is a very well-read intern. Check its work like you'd check a new hire's. The more it does, the more the human check matters.

Teach it *once.*

A chat starts cold every time. A Project remembers your files and your brief, so every chat in it starts warm. Set up one for the thing you explain every week.

05 Set up your first Project

01 Pick one job
The thing you explain to AI every single week.

02 Make the Project
Claude: Projects. ChatGPT: Projects. Gemini: Gems.

03 Paste the brief
Use the template below as its instructions.

04 Add the files
The documents it should always know. Names out.

05 Ask, then check
New chat inside the Project. Review it like a new hire's work.

PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS TEMPLATE · FILL THE [BRACKETS]

```
You are my [role, e.g. tax research assistant]. Everything in this Project is my real work situation.

About me: I'm a [your role] at a [type of firm] in [city]. I mostly work on [type of clients or work].

How to work with me:
1. Ground every answer in the files here. Never invent figures, dates or citations. If the files don't say it, tell me.
2. Give me the answer first, then the detail.
3. Write in plain English, the way I'd write to a client.
4. Challenge me if my question is vague or my thinking is weak.
5. Keep answers short unless I ask for more.
```

06 What the free plans give you

TOOL	FREE PLAN, CHECKED 15 OCT 2026
Claude	Up to 5 Projects. Chat plus file upload.
Gemini	Gems. Chat plus file upload, lower limits.
ChatGPT	Projects are small (5 files). Uploads are limited.

Plans change often. Check the tool's pricing page before you build. Pick one tool, go deep for a month, then decide. The skill moves with you.

07 Pick the right brain

- **The sprinter** for quick lookups and fast rewrites.
- **The daily driver** for drafts, summaries and everyday asks. Live here.
- **The deep thinker** for tricky analysis. Go up only when the daily driver disappoints you.

Every tool has this picker next to the send button. Different names, same idea.

08 Save tokens, save money

AI reads and writes in tokens, about 100 tokens to 75 words. Writing costs about 5 times more than reading on most price lists, and every new message re-sends the whole chat. On a monthly plan you won't see a bill. You'll hit your limit sooner instead.

- Ask for the length and format you want. "5 bullets."
- New task, new chat.
- Paste the page, not the whole file.
- Small brain for small jobs.
- Ask for short answers. Writing is the expensive part.
- Get the brief right the first time.

09 Do one of these by Wednesday

1
Rewrite one prompt with the four parts.

2
Set up one Project for the thing you explain every week.

3
Upload the long thing you've been avoiding. Then check one section yourself.

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Thank you, PICPA and Dr Jill.
Made in Singapore, for Cagayan de Oro.